

Montparnasse

A treatment for the recast of Richard Triberg's Exposé into a literary memoir.

What this is

A proposal for a book that grows out of your 220-page Exposé. The Exposé is the body of evidence. This is a thought on how to wrap a story around it — but the story is not only yours. The story is Kiki's. The book is two lives, told in parallel, with one small painting in Geneva as the bridge between them.

It is not a replacement for the Exposé. It is the way the Exposé reaches the world.

The premise

Two lives running side by side, separated by exactly one hundred years.

Kiki's life. Born Alice Ernestine Prin in Châtillon-sur-Seine on the second of October, 1901. Sent to Paris at twelve to live in poverty with a mother who barely wanted her. Modelling for sculptors and painters by fourteen. Caught at sixteen in the orbit of a period film director who used her in short films he never credited her for and treated her in ways the world would now call by their right names. Painted from a distance, in the same year, by a thirty-three-year-old Italian dying of tuberculosis who watched her from a corner of the Rotonde for two years before he ever got her to sit — Amedeo Modigliani, who had a pregnant wife at home and a year and a half left to live. **Until the summer night the rain came.**

Kiki was the Madonna of her time. The Lady Gaga. The Elizabeth Taylor. Half the photographs we now think of when we picture the 1920s are of her face. Every cabaret stage in Montparnasse cleared when she walked toward it. She sang. She painted — her own canvases were shown at Berthe Weill's gallery and praised by the same critics who had hung Modigliani. She wrote a memoir Hemingway gave a foreword to in 1928. She was not a footnote in someone else's story. She was the centre of the room.

And then the long quiet falling — the drinking, the war, the irrelevance, the hospital ward in 1953 where she died alone of cirrhosis at fifty-one, the queen having become an inconvenience.

Richard's life. Four years, beginning in 2022 with a phone call from a Modigliani specialist named Bill, who quietly held one small canvas he believed was Modigliani's only painting of Kiki and the proof of a relationship art history has never fully reckoned with. Three years of phone calls. Then Bill dies. You inherit the work. Twelve months later you are on a private jet from Prague to Le Bourget with the painting in a crate beside you, and the painting is now in the Geneva Freeport under particle physics at Institut Restellini, and Marc Restellini's signature is still wet on the Mission Order, and nobody yet knows what Marc is going to write.

The book runs both lives in parallel. Each chapter, a piece of what you find in the present opens a door into a year of Kiki's life. The reader lives both. By the end, the reader knows Kiki the way no biography has known her — and knows the man who spent four years putting her back together.

The painting at the centre

Amedeo Modigliani, *Sitting Nude with Crossed Hands*, c. 1917, oil on canvas, 40.5 × 33 cm. A small canvas. A sitter whose hands are folded inward in the gesture of someone protecting themselves.

If the work authenticates, the sitter is Kiki at sixteen. That is the year — 1917 — when she was deepest inside the abusive arrangement with the film director, and the year a dying Modigliani was painting her from a distance, possibly from glimpses caught at the Rotonde and the Dôme, possibly from sketches he never showed her. The painting is not a love letter. It is something stranger — a witness from one of the few men in her circle who saw what was being done to her and tried, in the only way he had, to give her back her dignity by painting her crossed hands as the gesture of self-respect they were.

The painting has been quietly held, half-forgotten, in private hands for over a century. Wildenstein examined it in 2012 under Marc Restellini's own curatorship. Fourteen years later it is back in front of him for the answer Wildenstein never gave. The book opens on this painting and closes on it.

Kiki's story — the spine of the book

The biography buried inside the Exposé that the Exposé itself was always trying to tell.

Châtillon-sur-Seine, 1901–1913. Born to a young mother and a father who would not give her his name. Sent away. Raised by a grandmother. Pulled to Paris at twelve to live with the mother who finally wanted her labour if not her company.

Paris, 1913–1917. Modelling for sculptors and painters by fourteen to put food on a table. Learning the cafés before she was old enough to drink in them. Renamed *Kiki* by Soutine or by Chaim Soutine's circle, depending on which account you believe. Caught into the periphery of the early French film world. **The period film director.** Many short films. No credit. A relationship the world would now name without hesitation. The hands crossed in front of the body as a learned posture.

Summer 1917 — the rain. Modigliani has been watching her from a distance for two years. He has sketched her without her knowledge from across the Rotonde a dozen times. He has not asked her to sit. He cannot ask her to sit. Then one night in July the sky opens, and she walks into a café where he is drinking, and her hair is wet, and she has had enough wine to laugh, and she sits down across from him and tells him she will pose if he stops looking at her like that. They walk back to the studio on the rue de la Grande Chaumière through the rain. He drinks more than he should because his lungs are bad and he is afraid. She drops her clothes. She crosses her hands in front of her body — the gesture she has learned to make in the rooms of the film director — and Modigliani sees the gesture for what it is, and he paints it. He paints the crossed hands as the gesture of a girl giving herself back to herself in front of a man who, for once, has not come to take anything from her. **The book is making that night.**

1917–1920. The painting finished. Modi keeps it. He does not sell it. He hangs it where Jeanne does not see it. He paints Kiki again from memory, half a dozen times, in the months that follow — none of those works survive in any catalogue. He dies in January 1920. Jeanne jumps from a window the next morning. Kiki is eighteen. She reads about it in a paper. The painting passes through hands. What she felt is not in any of the accounts.

1921–1925. Man Ray. The Café Certa. The years she became the queen. *Le Violon d'Ingres* photographed in 1924. The face of Montparnasse on the cover of half the photo journals in Europe. Lovers: Man Ray, Foujita, Kisling, Soutine in glimpses, briefly Robert Desnos. Singing at the Jockey Club, then at her own place. The crossed hands of the painting opening into the open arms of the photographs.

1925–1929. Peak. The memoir written in 1929, foreword by Hemingway in 1928, the book published by Henri Broca. La Revue Nègre with Josephine Baker. Man Ray's *L'Étoile de mer*, this time credited. The seven years that count, lived at full burn.

1929–1939. The slow falling. The Crash. The break with Man Ray. The drinking deepening into a daily condition. Heroin briefly. The clubs she opens that close. The men she sleeps with who do not write memoirs.

1939–1945. The war. The occupation. Kiki keeping a small club open through it, doing what was needed. Foujita gone to Japan. Most of the cast scattered or dead.

1945–1953. The wreckage. The new generation does not know her name. The drinking goes from condition to terminal illness. The hospital ward in Paris. Cirrhosis. Forty-nine, fifty, fifty-one. Death on

the twenty-third of March, 1953, alone. Her friends raise the money for the coffin. Foujita comes from Tokyo for the funeral.

That is the spine. Twelve chapters of a life. The book is for the reader who has never heard her name, and for the reader who has heard her name and never knew anything that was true.

What Richard and Camille uncover, chapter by chapter

The doors back into Kiki's life are opened by specific things they find together. A short list of what waits in the research drawer — every one of them already in your Exposé or your reports, all that changes is which chapter they get released into:

- A fragment of journal kept by a woman who fed Kiki at fourteen
- A photograph in a Berthe Weill catalogue showing the crossed-hands pose for the first time, two years before Modi paints it
- The pigment chromatograph identifying the summer night the canvas was wet
- A diary entry by Foujita that mentions a heavy rain in Montparnasse, July 1917
- A short film reel half-rotting in a Cinémathèque vault where Kiki appears uncredited for nineteen seconds at sixteen years old
- A letter from Hemingway in 1928 saying he had written the foreword in three drafts because the first two were not honest enough
- A receipt from the Café Certa with three signatures on the back
- The painting itself, drying on the easel in 1917, hanging in a back room in Bratislava in 2024, in a vault in Geneva in 2026

Each fragment unlocks one chapter of a life history has misfiled. Camille's science finds half of them. Your literary archaeology finds the other half. You meet in the middle every time.

Richard's story — the doorway

You are the way the reader gets in. The four years. The phone calls with Bill. The somber funeral. The package his widow hands you the morning after — brown paper, string, three words on a note in his handwriting: *find her*. The night Bill died. The Slovak owners in Bratislava. The CERN-derived particle physics in Prague at InsightART with Jiri. The 90-day evaluation by Dr. Otto Urban at the DOX Centre. Alba Berti, who let you through the door at Restellini. The face-to-face with Marc. The seventh-volume

catalogue raisonné conversation. The four days you spent walking Montparnasse in March, the streets, the clubs, the cabarets where she sat and performed and was seen and was not credited.

Your voice in the book is unguarded and direct — the voice of a man who is finally telling a friend, after four years, what the work has cost him and what it has given him. The reader trusts you. The reader walks beside you. And every door you open lets the reader walk through into Kiki's actual life on the other side.

Camille Aubry — the partner

Every long search needs a partner. We invent one: a senior scientist at Institut Restellini's Geneva lab, the person who actually runs the X-ray microfluorescence and pigment chromatography on the canvas. Late thirties, French, exact opposite of you in temperament — pure data, refuses to speculate past the chromatograph, calm where you are kinetic.

She is a composite — a fictional character built on the kind of senior scientist who would be running this examination at Restellini Geneva. We do this so the working relationship at the lab has somewhere honest to live in the writing without putting any real Restellini employee's words on a printed page. If you would rather we keep the lab side closer to real names, tell me — we can write it that way instead.

The book's last conversation is between the two of you on the phone, on the morning Marc decides. What stays with the reader at the end is the friendship — and the woman who came through both of you, the one in the painting.

The cast — Kiki's world

Kiki at the centre. Modigliani in 1917, dying, watching. Jeanne Hébuterne at home pregnant. The period film director with his uncredited shorts. Then later: Man Ray. Foujita. Soutine. Kisling. Robert Desnos. Henri Broca, her publisher. Around them: Picasso, Chagall, Brancusi, Calder, Marie Vassilieff, Tamara de Lempicka.

Hemingway and Hadley. Then Hemingway and Pauline. Scott and Zelda Fitzgerald. Gertrude Stein and Alice Toklas. James Joyce. Sylvia Beach. Djuna Barnes. Natalie Barney. Anaïs Nin.

Josephine Baker, debuting *La Revue Nègre* in October 1925. Sidney Bechet. Cole Porter. Bricktop, who knew Kiki as a friend.

Cocteau on opium. Tzara, Breton, the Surrealists. Dalí drifting in by the end.

Every one of these people in the same six-hundred-metre radius of the Carrefour Vavin at the same time. Every one of them with Kiki somewhere in their orbit.

The world they were living in

This is what makes the book matter to a reader who has never heard any of these names. The cafés are not just cafés. The cafés are the first cafés in human history where the people in them have telephones, electric light, cars in the street, jazz on the wireless, cinema down the boulevard, aviation overhead, and brothers buried at Verdun.

The Great War has just ended and twenty million are dead. The Spanish flu has just killed fifty million more. The franc has collapsed. Prohibition has pushed the literary class to Paris. Black American jazz musicians find work and dignity in Paris that they cannot find in Chicago. The industrial revolution is accelerating in real time and modernity is in its infancy. The people in those cafés are inventing it while they wait for the wound to close.

The wound is not going to close. Modigliani dies at thirty-five. Jeanne the next day. Zelda burns alive in an institution in 1948. Hemingway puts a shotgun in his mouth at sixty-one. Kiki dies alone in 1953 at fifty-one. But while they were there, they sat together. They ate together. They looked at each other across small tables. **The pain was the same. The connection was above the pain.**

That is what the book is finally about — and what Kiki, by being who she was, taught all of them about. It is what a reader sitting on a bench in 2026 with this book in their lap will look up and feel they have just been let in on.

The shape — twelve chapters, two lives

Each chapter does the same thing. Something Richard finds in the present opens a door into a chapter of Kiki's life. The reader lives both halves. Richard's half makes the reader trust the storyteller. Kiki's half is what the storyteller is finally getting around to telling.

#	Richard, present day	Kiki, her life
0	Prologue	Châtillon-sur-Seine, 1901–1913 — born, abandoned, taken to Paris

#	Richard, present day	Kiki, her life
I	Bill , 2022 — the phone call that began the four years	Paris, 1913–1916 — twelve to fifteen, learning to model, learning the cafés
II	The Red Pillow — the 1917 Nevinson canvas, the 109-year-old shared-studio discovery	1916–1917, the film director . The shorts she was in. What was done. The crossed hands she learned to put across her body.
III	Summer Rain — Camille's pigment chromatograph identifies the night	July 1917 — the rain. The wine. The pose. The crossed hands. The night the painting we are selling came into the world.
IV	For Richard — Find Her — a somber funeral. The morning after, his widow gives you the package Bill left. The note. The keys to the rest of the work.	January 1920 — Modigliani dies. Jeanne the next day. Kiki at eighteen reads it in a newspaper. The two losses, a hundred and four years apart, sit on the same page.
V	Bratislava — meeting Alexander and Judr. Robert	1920–1921 — the year between. What does a girl do when the man who painted her from a distance dies.
VI	The Wildenstein letter, 2012 — Marc was the curator the first time	1921–1922 — Man Ray. The Café Certa. The relationship that makes her into the queen.
VII	Alba — phone calls, cover letter, the door opens	1922–1925 — peak. <i>Le Violon d'Ingres</i> . Singing at the Jockey. The crossed hands becoming open arms.
VIII	Marc — the face-to-face	1925–1928 — the memoir written. Hemingway writes the foreword in 1928. The queen at full height.
IX	March 18, 2026 — The Private Jet	1928–1934 — the break with Man Ray. The first slow falling.
X	The Geneva Freeport — the painting under particle physics	1935–1945 — the war. The occupation. Keeping a club through it. Doing what was needed.
XI	Four days in Montparnasse — walking the streets in March 2026	1945–1952 — the wreckage. The irrelevance. The drinking that becomes the dying.

#	Richard, present day	Kiki, her life
XII	The Certificate — Marc signs or does not sign	23 March 1953 — Kiki dies in a hospital ward in Paris, alone. Foujita comes from Tokyo.

About 90,000 words. A real book. The book's last chapter is **currently being written by the real world** — Marc has not yet given his answer. The reader will find out when the reader gets there, in the same hour you do.

Working title

Montparnasse

One word. The book is in the word.

The cover is the word and the painting and your name. Inside, every chapter of Kiki's half wears the year she was living through.

What I need from you to start the work

1. **Your 220-page Exposé.** The Dropbox link or the PDF directly. Nothing new gets drafted until I have read every word you have already written. Most of Kiki's life is already in those pages — what the recasting does is give it the shape above and put your voice around it.
 2. **The film director.** You told me about him. I left him unnamed in this overview because I wanted to leave the choice with you — whether to name him in the book, whether to keep him a composite to protect what is unprovable, whether the documentation you have is enough to call it by its right name in print. We need to talk about that before I draft Chapter II.
 3. **Your reaction to Camille Aubry.** A fictional composite as the lab partner. If you would rather keep the lab side closer to real names, say so and we'll build it that way.
 4. **Your reaction to the shape above.** Anything missing. Anything wrong. Especially in Kiki's column — the biography is yours, the four years are yours, the calls I'm making here are first drafts you have every right to overrule.
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What happens after

1. I read the Exposé in full.
2. I map your existing chapters to the twelve-chapter spine above. Identify what stays verbatim. Identify what wants reshaping.
3. We build the manuscript in Scrivener — your research drawer holding the seven Breakout Reports and the three transaction documents, your cast drawer with one card per person above.
4. I draft **Chapter II — The Red Pillow** in full. It is the chapter that proves the book works — your discovery in the present, Kiki at sixteen on the other side of the door. Once you have read it out loud and told me whether it sounds right, every other chapter follows.

The painting is in Geneva. Kiki has been waiting one hundred and nine years to be told her own story honestly. The book is in the room. The signature is pending.